

Subject: Eligibility Requirements**Item: Overview**

PURPOSE:

To provide an overview of the eligibility requirements for WIC program participation.

POLICY:

- I. Local agency (LA) staff must certify an applicant for program participation if the applicant meets WIC eligibility requirements for category, residency, income, and nutritional risk.
 - A. A family representative may apply for WIC program participation on behalf of an infant or child. Refer to WPPM 290-00.
 - B. A caretaker is an individual designated by a participant or family representative to act on their behalf. Refer to WPPM 290-10.

PROCEDURES:

- I. LA staff must attempt to collect proofs of eligibility in advance of certification or recertification appointments to help identify any missing items and streamline the certification process.
- II. The following eligibility criteria must be met and documented in the WIC Web Information System Exchange (WIC WISE) for an applicant to be certified for program participation:
 - A. Be in a category served by WIC:
 1. Pregnant (prenatal) individual. Refer to WPPM 210-08.
 2. Breastfeeding individual up to one year postpartum.
 3. Non-breastfeeding individual up to six months postpartum.
 4. Infant up to 12 months old.
 5. Child under the age of five years.
 - B. Reside in California. Refer to WPPM 210-06.
 - C. Meet income eligibility criteria. Refer to WPPM 210-01 through 210-04.
 - D. Have an indicator of nutritional risk. Refer to WPPM 210-09 through 210-13.
- III. LA staff must grant a 30-day short certification period if an applicant can only provide proof for two of the three required documents to determine eligibility (e.g., identity, residency, and income).
 - A. In cases of missing proofs, LA staff must clearly inform the applicant: (1) To provide the necessary proof needed for program eligibility within 30 days, (2) of

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the consequences of failing to do so, which can lead to being found ineligible for WIC and terminated.

- B. If an applicant is missing more than one required proof, the applicant cannot be certified, even for a shortened certification period. LA staff must advise the applicant to return to the clinic and re-apply once they can provide the necessary proofs of WIC eligibility.

IV. Presence at Certification

- A. The applicant must be present at certification unless they meet an approved exemption criterion. This requirement is temporarily waived until September 30, 2026. Refer to WPPM 200-00.

V. Identification (ID) at Certification

- A. The applicant must provide proof of ID at certification. Refer to WPPM 270-20.

VI. Miscellaneous

- A. Certification must be provided at no cost to the applicant.
- B. The LA must ensure that no person is subjected to discrimination. Refer to WPPM 510-10.
- C. WIC program participation is available to any individual who meets the program eligibility requirements. United States citizenship is not required.

AUTHORITY:

[7 CFR 246.7\(c\), \(l\)](#)

[7 CFR 246.8](#)

[WIC Policy Memorandum #2023-6: Streamlining Certification](#)

CROSS REFERENCE:

WPPM 200-00 Physical Presence Waiver for Certifications and Recertifications

WPPM 210-01 General Income Eligibility Guidelines and Procedures

WPPM 210-02 Adjunctive Eligibility

WPPM 210-03 Determination of Income Eligibility

WPPM 210-04 Income Exclusions

WPPM 210-06 Proof of California Residency

WPPM 210-07 Presence Requirement

WPPM 210-08 Proof of Pregnancy

WPPM 210-09 Overview – Nutrition Assessment Requirement for All Categories

WPPM 210-10 Determining Nutritional Risk – Anthropometric

CERTIFICATION

WPPM #200-01

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WPPM 210-11 Determining Nutritional Risk – Biochemical

WPPM 210-12 Determining Nutritional Risk – Clinical/Health/Medical

WPPM 210-13 Determining Nutritional Risk – Dietary

WPPM 270-20 Proof of Identity

WPPM 290-00 Family Representative

WPPM 290-10 Designation of Caretaker

WPPM 510-10 Nondiscrimination